

The Role of *Stolpersteine* in Creating a German National Identity

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Germans stumble over their Nazi history a lot. Quite literally. *Stolpersteine*, or “stumbling stones,” are small, 10 × 10 cm brass plaques displaying the name of a Holocaust victim, embedded into German sidewalks in front of the victim’s last residence before deportation.¹ Since 1995, Cologne artist Gunter Demnig has installed 100,000 *Stolpersteine* across Europe, most of them in Germany, to commemorate the atrocities of the Third Reich.² Like every memorial, they tell a story about what a country appreciates, honors, and celebrates. Unlike every memorial, however, they are small, inconspicuous, and increasingly woven into German urban architecture. Their purpose also goes beyond sole commemoration: *Stolpersteine* express a deeply felt sense of historical guilt and exemplify how German citizens craft their national identity by confronting their Nazi past. Identity is shaped by the public discourse on how best to deal with the past, particularly in light of the recent rise in far-right extremism.

The installation of *Stolpersteine* in 1,200 German cities³ exemplifies how the German state commits to the collective commemoration of Germany’s Nazi past. In a speech delivered in 2020, President Frank-Walter Steinmeier declared, “We fight antisemitism! We protect Jewish life!”⁴ a statement that shows how the German state publicly commits to taking responsibility for the atrocities of the Holocaust. This is primarily achieved through the promotion of a “culture of remembrance,” predicated on the assumption that a shared “collective memory”⁵ of Germany’s Nazi past prevents its recurrence. In contrast to the remote, isolated locations of Holocaust memorials such as the prominent Memorial to the Murdered Jews of Europe in Berlin, which must be intentionally sought out, *Stolpersteine* ubiquitously create historical awareness in public places.⁶ Blending

¹ Curtet, “Stolpersteine,” 2023.

² Demnig, *Stolpersteine*, 2023.

³ Endlich, “Porträt – ‘Die Worte sollen hart und kurz sein’,” *Der Freitag*, 2020.

⁴ Staff, “‘Laden with Guilt’: Full Text of German President’s World Holocaust Forum Speech,” *The Times of Israel*, 2020.

⁵ Erll, *Kollektives Gedächtnis und Erinnerungskulturen*, 2008.

⁶ Harjes, “Stumbling Stones: Holocaust Memorials, National Identity, and Democratic Inclusion in Berlin,” *German Politics & Society* 23, no. 1 (2005): 138–51.

into the city's architecture, they establish a dialogue between the present and the past, prompting pedestrians to recollect the systematic extermination of Jews that took place on the very street they walk roughly eighty years later.⁷ They therefore also confront Germans with the discomfort of their past, giving rise to a widely accepted feeling of "collective guilt."⁸ The acceptance of this notion of guilt is, however, relatively recent, dating to the 1968 movement, in which the post-war generation began to challenge the war generation on its historical responsibility. This led to the emergence of civil initiatives that placed emphasis on the "dark chapter" of German history.⁹ *Stolpersteine* exemplify the changing German attitude toward the state's acceptance of historical guilt: Gunter Demnig received public permission for his *Stolpersteine* project only four years after he had already, illegally, installed nearly a thousand of them.¹⁰ The state's support for the initiative is perhaps best captured by former Chancellor Angela Merkel's remark, delivered at the official commemoration of the seventy-fifth anniversary of Kristallnacht, that she held "high praise for the *Stolpersteine* [...], they remind us of an indelible part of our history." This statement illustrates how deeply *Stolpersteine* are bound to the openly avowed feelings of grief and remembrance at the heart of German politics. The German state's growing support for the *Stolperstein* project as a means of commemoration thus crafts a national identity grounded not only in identification with a shared past, but in the shared feeling of guilt that accompanies it.

The fact that the research, crafting, financing, and ritual cleaning of Germany's *Stolpersteine* lies largely in private hands shows that the culture of remembrance is not merely an abstract, state-imposed concept, but one chosen by Germans themselves as part of their national identity. The name, date of death, and home address of every Holocaust victim honored by a *Stolperstein* must be researched by citizens, who may then request that a stone be crafted for a fee of €120.¹¹ This democratization of commemoration illustrates how "conceptions of national identity and historical responsibility [develop] from the bottom up."¹² Unlike other official memorials, the success of the *Stolpersteine* project rests on private rather than state initiative, echoing political scientist Ruth Dittmann's empirical finding that forty percent of Germans recognize a "special historical responsibility."¹³ This recognition leads them to discover unconventional ways of shaping the German cultural landscape. *Stolpersteine* allow for the materialization of this sense of responsibility, showing, in a rather beautiful way, how German citizens interweave historical reflection with architecture to symbolize a commitment to tolerance and anti-fascism. Indeed, *Stolpersteine* have encouraged students and citizens in more than 1,200 cities to research the past lives of local Holocaust victims.¹⁴ Every year on November 9, groups gather to ritually clean the stones¹⁵—a decentralized national observance that shows how Germans actively embrace their history to shape the

⁷ Cook and van Riemsdijk, "Agents of Memorialization," *Journal of Historical Geography* 43 (2014): 138–47.

⁸ Zyllicz and Poleszak, "Naturalistic Conception of Collective Guilt," *Humboldt Journal of Social Relations* 29, no. 2 (2005): 185–206.

⁹ Roos, 2006.

¹⁰ Demnig, *Stolpersteine*, 2023.

¹¹ Demnig, *Stolpersteine*, 2023.

¹² Harjes, "Stumbling Stones," 2005.

¹³ Dittmann and Kopf-Beck, "The Meaning of Being German," *Journal of Social and Political Psychology* 7, no. 1 (2019): 423–47.

¹⁴ Blatt, "Holocaust Memory and Germany," *The Public Historian* 34, no. 4 (2012): 53–66.

¹⁵ Thomas, "9. November 1938: Stolpersteine putzen, um an Opfer zu erinnern," SPD Berlin, 2020.

cultural landscape. The project succeeds, in part, because it offers German citizens a chance to act directly upon their sense of responsibility, rather than passively commemorating historical sites that already contain “ready-made interpretations”¹⁶ of the past. This makes *Stolpersteine* truly “a memorial by and for the Germans,”¹⁷ with citizens personally contributing to the preservation of Holocaust memory. National identity is thus built on the individual actions that arise from the personal responsibility many Germans feel toward their nation’s past.

Conservative activists have nonetheless criticized the effectiveness and appropriateness of *Stolpersteine*, giving rise to debates over how properly to reckon with Germany’s past. Responding to the temporary banning of *Stolpersteine* in Munich in 2004, historian Kirsten Harjes observed that their scattered, inconspicuous character can turn meaningful memorials into “familiar, unnoticed objects,”¹⁸ producing a kind of historical desensitization. At the time, Charlotte Knobloch, former president of the Central Council of Jews in Germany, further objected that *Stolpersteine* are an undignified way of remembering Holocaust victims, whose names are literally “trampled underfoot.”¹⁹ A survey of the map of Cologne shows that *Stolpersteine* do tend to cluster in areas that also serve as tourist attractions, raising further questions about their effectiveness:²⁰ because they convey no detailed information on their own, they arguably rely on citizens’ existing knowledge of the Holocaust²¹ rather than adding to a broader historical consciousness. Yet the very variety of responses to this criticism shows how central the debate over Germany’s past remains to a common national identity. In 2017, Demnig clarified that *Stolpersteine* are meant above all to humanize history: rather than collectivizing the deaths of thirteen million Holocaust victims, they emphasize the individual humanity of each victim, allowing for an “authentic memory” of the Holocaust that evokes emotion and empathy.²² This project is complicated by the recent rise of the Alternative für Deutschland (AfD), elements of which minimize the Holocaust,²³ charging that *Stolpersteine* “dictate a state-imposed remembrance culture” and thereby reigniting the underlying debate. Instances in which *Stolpersteine* have been vandalized or destroyed have provoked considerable public outrage and condemnation, revealing just how seriously acts of disrespect toward Germany’s confrontation with its Nazi history are regarded. The controversy surrounding *Stolpersteine* thus shows how a substantial part of German national identity arises from disagreement over how correctly to engage with the country’s Nazi past. That political currents continue to shape this discourse suggests that a culture of remembrance is strengthened not only through acts of commemoration but through the direct confrontation of opposing, critical, or denialist views.

In conclusion, *Stolpersteine* exemplify the German struggle to come to terms with its Nazi past. On one hand, they enjoy both private and institutional support: the German state officially backs the *Stolpersteine* project to demonstrate its commitment to a culture of remembrance, while private funding, research, and cleaning show how individual

¹⁶ Harjes, “Stumbling Stones,” 2005.

¹⁷ Blatt, “Holocaust Memory and Germany,” 2012.

¹⁸ Harjes, “Stumbling Stones,” 2005.

¹⁹ Wetzel, “Debatte um Stolpersteine – Gedenken, das entzweit,” *Süddeutsche Zeitung*, 2014.

²⁰ Stadt Köln, “Stolpersteine,” 2023.

²¹ Harjes, “Stumbling Stones,” 2005.

²² Demnig, quoted in Gilman, “Memory Blocks,” *Smithsonian Magazine*, 2017.

²³ Kahn, 2022.

Germans craft their identity from the bottom up. On the other hand, *Stolpersteine* also reveal how far-right attacks on this commitment to history reopen debate over how best to honor Germany's special responsibility. German national identity, then, is less a fixed set of shared values than an ongoing process of debate and activism: it rests not simply on a shared Nazi past, as is often argued, but on the continuing discourse over how correctly to confront and commemorate it.

Word count: 1396

REFERENCES

- Blatt, M. (2012). Holocaust Memory and Germany. *The Public Historian*, 34(4), 53–66. <https://doi.org/10.1525/tph.2012.34.4.53>
This personal travelogue describes a trip to Heidelberg, Germany, and the city's 2011 program for Jewish citizens celebrating Jewish life in Germany. It also highlights the gratitude and healing that Stolpersteine provide to descendants of Holocaust victims, drawing on interviews with German Jews. Used to demonstrate how civic engagement for Jewish commemoration leads to the preservation of history.
- Cook, M., & van Riemsdijk, M. (2014). Agents of memorialization: Gunter Demnig's Stolpersteine and the individual (re-)creation of a Holocaust landscape in Berlin. *Journal of Historical Geography*, 43, 138–147. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.jhg.2013.09.001>
This source takes a geographic approach to how the choice and design of Holocaust memorials in Germany affect their public perception and shape different modes of commemoration. It highlights the role of individuals in shaping the German cultural landscape, drawing on interviews with participants in Stolperstein installations as well as media accounts of the campaign. Useful for its focus on the individual level of commemoration and the significance of the stones' inconspicuous nature.
- Ditlmann, R. K., & Kopf-Beck, J. (2019). The meaning of being German: An inductive approach to national identity. *Journal of Social and Political Psychology*, 7(1), 423–447. <https://doi.org/10.5964/jpspp.v7i1.557>
This source takes an empirical approach to identifying the components of German national identity by surveying 987 German citizens. After sorting responses into categories in which language and culture predominate, the authors conclude that an awareness of history underlies most categories. A major source in supporting the claim that Germans recognize their historical guilt.
- Endlich, N. (2020, April). Porträt – “Die Worte sollen hart und kurz sein” [The words should be harsh and brief]. *Der Freitag*. <https://www.freitag.de/autoren/nikola-endlich/die-orte-sollen-hart-und-kurz-sein>
This newspaper article shows how the installation of Stolpersteine can be a tool for coming to terms with one's family past, and explains how the stones are crafted and installed. Useful for understanding both the design process and the personal meaning the stones carry.
- Erl, A. (2008). Kollektives Gedächtnis und Erinnerungskulturen [Collective memory and cultures of remembrance]. *J.B. Metzler eBooks*, 156–157. https://doi.org/10.1007/978-3-476-05057-1_8
The introduction highlights the problems arising from the scarcity of personal accounts of the past and the resulting need for accurate, engaging modes of commemoration, as well as the role of media and political scientists in preserving collective historical consciousness. Used primarily to understand Germany's culture of remembrance and its relation to Stolpersteine.
- Gilman, L. (2017, October). Memory Blocks. *Smithsonian Magazine*. <https://www.smithsonianmag.com/arts-culture/memory-blocks-173123976/>
A chronicle of the history of Stolpersteine in Germany, from initial illegality and rejection to current acceptance, presenting the viewpoints of major historians such as James Young alongside particular examples of commemorated individuals. Introduced the controversies surrounding Stolpersteine and led to further exploration of Knobloch's criticism.
- Harjes, K. (2005). Stumbling stones: Holocaust memorials, national identity, and democratic

inclusion in Berlin. *German Politics & Society*, 23(1/74), 138–151. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/23740916>

Presents a two-sided view of Stolpersteine, focusing on the metaphorical and biblical allusions of the term. Highlights how Stolpersteine distinguish themselves from other memorials and produce a more humanized, personal mode of commemoration. Used throughout to present both criticism of Stolpersteine and the importance of local communities in sustaining this personal form of commemoration.

Stadt Köln. (2023). Stolpersteine. *Www.stadt-koeln.de*. <https://www.stadt-koeln.de/leben-in-koeln/kultur/stolpersteine/index.html>

This official city map of Cologne shows the exact location of the 2,400 Stolpersteine in the city and contains an extensive, up-to-date database of victims' names, addresses, and residence districts, filterable by street. Used to learn about the distribution of Stolpersteine in the author's home city; revealed a clustering in touristy areas that raised questions about their effectiveness.

Staff, T. (2020, January). "Laden with guilt": Full text of German president's World Holocaust Forum speech. *The Times of Israel*. <https://www.timesofisrael.com/laden-with-guilt-full-text-of-german-presidents-world-holocaust-forum-speech/>

Contains the transcript of President Frank-Walter Steinmeier's speech of January 23, 2020, in Jerusalem, emphasizing the German state's active commitment to protecting Jews and commemorating its Nazi history in highly emotional language. Useful for understanding the official state attitude toward the promotion of memory culture.

Thomas, S. (2020, November 9). 9. November 1938: Stolpersteine putzen, um an Opfer zu erinnern [November 9, 1938: Cleaning *Stolpersteine* to commemorate victims] – SPD Berlin. *Spd.berlin*. <https://spd.berlin/magazin/vorwaerts/9-november-1938-stolpersteine-putzen/>

This source by the SPD Berlin encourages citizens to clean Stolpersteine and explains the practice's symbolism, situating it explicitly within Berlin's Holocaust history and its effects on antisemitism today. One of many possible examples of how political parties organize local, small-scale acts of commemoration around Stolpersteine.

Wetzel, J. (2014, October 13). Debatte um Stolpersteine – Gedenken, das entzweit [The debate on *Stolpersteine* – polarizing commemoration]. *Süddeutsche.de*. <https://www.sueddeutsche.de/muenchen/debatte-um-stolpersteine-gedenken-das-entzweit-1.2170096>

Summarizes the controversy over the banning of Stolpersteine in Munich in 2004 and Charlotte Knobloch's role in promoting it, highlighting her view that the stones are an undignified mode of commemoration insofar as people step on them without appreciation. Presents an important counterargument from the perspective of a Jewish activist.

Zylicz, P. O., & Poleszak, L. (2005). Naturalistic conception of collective guilt. *Humboldt Journal of Social Relations*, 29(2), 185–206. <https://www.jstor.org/stable/23262801>

Explores the concept of historical guilt in relation to antisemitism as a comparatively modern phenomenon. Although focused on Poland, it also treats Germany as a case of successfully internalized historical guilt. Used to understand the theoretical notion of historical guilt and to frame Germany as a distinctive case of "collective historical guilt."